INTERNATIONAL GAMBLING STUDIES
https://doi.org/10.1080/14459795.2026.2748058

Routledge
Taylor & Francis Group

OPEN ACCESS Check for updates

From the love of the game: a qualitative study exploring mechanisms to online gambling participation in young people

Aino Suomi[a,b], Debbie Noble-Carr[a,b], Hunter Culbong[b] and Thomas Stevens[c]

[a]Centre for Gambling Research, Australian National University, Canberra, Australia; [b]POLIS: Centre for Social Policy Research, Australian National University, Canberra, Australia; [c]Youth Coalition of the ACT, Canberra, Australia

ABSTRACT

Emerging research has identified engagement in sports or video gaming as risk factors for gambling and gambling harm in young adults, but little is known about the mechanisms through which childhood engagement with these activities may lead to gambling in early adulthood. This qualitative study with 40 Australian young adults (aged 18–24 years) who self-identified as currently gambling online explored the factors they believed contributed to their uptake of gambling. Thematic analysis identified four common stages: (1) a love of 'the game' (video games or sports); (2) gambling becoming an inescapable part of the game; (3) gambling being seen as a way to enhance the game experience; and, for some, (4) gambling becoming a distinct activity in its own right, sometimes accompanied by gambling harm. Participants described how external factors, including universal gambling advertising, ease of access, and the normalization of gambling in their community, contributed to this progression. The similarity of these pathways across sport and gaming suggests shared mechanisms through which gambling becomes embedded in young people's leisure.

ARTICLE HISTORY
Received 3 November 2025
Accepted 3 October 2026

KEYWORDS
Sports betting; young adults; online gambling; video gaming; qualitative study

Young adults' increasing participation in online gambling and their consequent risk of gambling harm is an area of concern in and outside Australia. Online gambling refers to betting or wagering on a range of gambling services or products available on interactive media connected to the internet, including computers or mobile/digital devices (Gainsbury, 2015; Hing et al., 2022). In Australia, young adults over 18 years of age have access to regulated online gambling products including lottery or raffle tickets, sports and races betting, eSports betting, and Fantasy Sports betting. Despite the age restrictions, many young people under 18 also gain access to sports betting online (Greer et al., 2023; Jenkinson et al., 2018) as well as illegal online gambling on casino games or 'slot' machines widely available in Australia due to offshore gambling operators (Hing et al., 2021).

CONTACT Aino Suomi aino.suomi@anu.edu.au Centre for Gambling Research, The Australian National University, RSSS Building, 146 Ellery Crescent, Acton, Canberra, ACT 2601, Australia
Supplemental data for this article can be accessed online at https://doi.org/10.1080/14459795.2026.2748058.
© 2026 The Author(s). Published by Informa UK Limited, trading as Taylor & Francis Group.
This is an Open Access article distributed under the terms of the Creative Commons Attribution License (http://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/4.0/), which permits unrestricted use, distribution, and reproduction in any medium, provided the original work is properly cited. The terms on which this article has been published allow the posting of the Accepted Manuscript in a repository by the author(s) or with their consent.

While participation rates on land-based gambling have steadily decreased, rates of online gambling have increased exponentially in the past decade, particularly in the younger cohorts (Hing, Russell, et al., 2022; Suomi, Kim, et al., 2024). Recent Australian estimates of online gambling show that 34% of the Australian adult population had gambled online in the past 12 months as of January 2024 (Suomi, Hahn, et al., 2024), in comparison to 11% in 2021 and 8% in 2020 (Australian Communications and Media Authority, 2022). While young people 15–24 years of age are less likely to gamble compared to older age groups overall, we know that when they gamble, they are likely to be doing so online and are more likely to experience harms from their own gambling compared to older groups (Suomi, Hahn, et al., 2024).

Although access and ease of online technology use is undoubtedly one of the drivers of an uptake in online gambling, researchers have recently begun to focus on the impact of the 'gamblification' of children and young people's play, leisure, and entertainment activities, including sports and video games (Brock & Johnson, 2021; McGee, 2020). For example, due to the proliferation of gambling advertising, inducements, and sponsorships that exist across multiple sports, young people's immersion in sports or sports clubs has been singled out as one of the early risk factors for gambling and gambling harm (Constandt et al., 2022; Deans et al., 2017; McGee, 2020; Nyemcsok et al., 2021). In Australia the relationship between sports and gambling is considered increasingly symbiotic, with Australia's two major professional sports, the Australian Football League (AFL) and National Rugby League (NRL), being significantly involved in promotion of gambling products and services (Seal et al., 2022).

In addition to sports, young people are now commonly introduced to online gambling through their engagement with video games. Children as young as 12 years of age are regularly exposed to unregulated gambling-like features in video games, such as loot boxes and gacha (Delfabbro et al., 2021; Flayelle et al., 2023; Suomi, Hahn, et al., 2024). Recent studies show an estimated 44–78% of gamers have purchased loot boxes whilst playing video games (Spicer et al., 2022). The incorporation of gambling-like features in video games has blurred the line between gaming and gambling, as many of these features, including loot box and gacha mechanics meet the psychological or technical criteria for gambling (Drummond et al., 2020). Regardless of how they are defined and regulated, evidence suggests that engaging with gambling mechanics in video games may act as a 'gateway' to traditional gambling (González-Cabrera et al., 2023; Molde et al., 2019; Spicer et al., 2022). While evidence for the gateway hypothesis is currently limited (for recent reviews see: Delfabbro & King, 2020; Montiel et al., 2022), some research has found a reasonably strong association between purchasing loot boxes, problem gambling, and problem video gaming (Greer et al., 2022; Spicer et al., 2022). Research shows that young people are also more likely than older groups to engage with regulated betting associated with video game activities such as eSports or Fantasy sports (Jenny et al., 2017; Rockloff et al., 2025; Suomi, Kim, et al., 2024).

Existing research on gambling-gaming convergence suggests several possible pathways through which video gaming may contribute to later gambling participation, while also cautioning against a simple causal 'gateway' interpretation. Early conceptual work distinguished gaming and gambling as separate activities, while noting their increasing convergence through shared structural features, including chance-based rewards, monetized in-game items, virtual currencies, and gambling-themed content (King et al.,

2015). More recent reviews have found consistent evidence of associations between gaming involvement, loot box purchasing, esports betting, skin betting, and gambling-related problems, but conclude that the direction and nature of these relationships remain uncertain (Delfabbro & King, 2020; Siste et al., 2025).

Albarrán-Torres's (2018) concept of 'gamble-play' provides a useful lens for understanding gambling-gaming convergence, describing how digital gambling and gambling-like practices increasingly adopt the aesthetics, interfaces, and participatory features of video games. Such framing is relevant to young people's pathways into online gambling because it shifts attention from individual behavior alone to the media environments and cultural practices through which gambling becomes embedded in everyday leisure and play. This literature suggests that convergence may occur through multiple, overlapping processes, including exposure to gambling-like mechanics, normalization of spending money on chance-based outcomes, crossover between gaming and betting environments, and targeted gambling advertising within or around digital gaming cultures (Kim & King, 2020; Siste et al., 2025). However, the available evidence remains dominated by cross-sectional and correlational studies, with fewer studies examining how young people themselves describe the transition from gaming or sport engagement to online gambling initiation.

Despite compelling evidence that children and young people who engage with sports or video games may be at heightened risk for online gambling and gambling harm, less is known about how young people themselves understand the pathways through which these recreational activities may contribute to the initiation of online gambling. Informed by a public health perspective, this study examines gambling initiation as shaped not only by individual motivations, but also by broader social, commercial, and technological environments. Drawing on qualitative interviews with young adults who currently gamble online, this paper explores the factors that participants perceived as contributing to their uptake of online gambling, with a particular focus on how engagement with sport and video gaming may create pathways into gambling participation. Such knowledge, grounded in young adults' lived experience, is critical for informing public policy and gambling harm prevention strategies.

Method

Study approach

This exploratory phenomenological study examined why young adults initiate and continue online gambling. Phenomenology was used to explore young adults' subjective experiences by engaging directly with those who had experienced the phenomenon (Lester, 1999; Padgett, 2008). The approach encouraged participants to 'go back to the things themselves' (J. A. Smith et al., 2009) by reflecting on the contexts, conditions, and choices shaping their gambling pathways, while recognizing young adults as important contributors to knowledge (Bolzan & Gale, 2011; Gomez & Ryan, 2016).

The research team included a psychologist and gambling research academic, a social work academic, a youth worker, and a criminology PhD scholar who is also a young person. The study was informed by the view that young people have valuable insight into the social contexts, meanings, and motivations shaping their behavior. Participants were

not treated as able to provide objective causal explanations, but as able to reflect on their perceived pathways into online gambling, including the roles of peers, family, advertising, sport, video gaming, and broader social norms (Bragg, 2010; Hill, 2006; Husbands et al., 2020; Johnson, 2017).

Semi-structured interviews were designed to maximize participants' control over the research encounter, including choice over interview location, who was present, which questions they answered, and which issues they emphasized (Thomas et al., 2025; Waller & Bitou, 2011). This flexible approach sought to reduce traditional power imbalances between adult researchers and youth participants (Purdy & Spears, 2020), while identifying perceived points of influence, exposure and intervention relevant to gambling harm prevention.

Participants

The study was approved by the Australian National University Human Ethics Research Committee (protocol #2022/457). Participants were recruited through the community, using flyers, social media, and local news media advertising. A total of 40 young adults, aged 18–24 years who were living, studying, or working in Australian Capital Territory, and who self-identified as having an experience of online gambling in the last 12 months opted-in to participate in semi-structured in-depth interviews. As shown in Table 1, 17 participants described they engaged in 'traditional' online gambling (mainly sports or race betting). Fifteen participants only participated in online gambling that was directly associated with their own video game play or they gambled on other people playing video games ('e-sports' gambling). A further eight participants discussed engaging in gambling in both video gaming and more traditional gambling using online platforms. These eight participants predominantly first encountered and engaged in gambling in the context of playing video games and then became aware of or interested in other gambling activities (including sports betting) as they aged and as their interests broadened. More detailed information on the characteristics of the participants are shown in Table 1.

Data collection

In-depth qualitative interviews were carried out between March and September 2023 and ranged from 25 minutes to 130 minutes (Mean 47 minutes). Participants were offered a $50 digital debit card as thanks for their time. Interviews were semi-structured

Table 1. Age, gender, and type of play profiles of 40 participants.

Characteristic	Categories	n
Age	18–19	8
	20–21	16
	22–23	12
	24	4
Sex	Female	8
	Male	32
Type of play	Video Gaming (with gambling features) only	15
	Online Gambling only	17
	Video Gaming and Online Gambling	8

including open-ended questions around predetermined interview topics including initial uptake of gambling (age at onset and what was happening in their lives at the time); types of online gambling activity (the specific gambling types they engaged with over time); their online gambling motivations (i,e. what prompted them to start or keep gambling), attitudes (of themselves, their peers, and family to their gambling), expectations (around gambling activities) and any relevant gambling experiences (feelings, thoughts, or instances of gambling that they want to share). The interview prompts are detailed in Appendix 1.

Data analysis

The interviews were recorded (with the permission of the participants), transcribed, and imported into NVivo v12 to aid qualitative analysis. The data were analyzed using a dualistic technique of deductive and inductive thematic analysis (Fereday & Muir-Cochrane, 2006; Roberts et al., 2019; Saldana, 2016). Initial deductive analysis allowed key themes to be developed in line with the key interview topics such as: 'onset of gambling,' 'gambling types,' 'gambling motivation,' and 'gambling experiences.' Data was allocated into these 'topic summaries' and sub-codes were developed and refined, with two researchers (HC & AS) systematically searching for similarities and differences across the incidents and contexts revealed in the interviews (Padgett, 2008). This process allowed us to store and sort data within larger topic areas to ensure we were able to provide a findings summary for our funding body that directly answered some of our key research questions.

To extract further nuance and meaning from the data, researchers then employed inductive analysis techniques. The identification of inductive themes was guided by a thematic analysis process described by Braun and Clarke (2006): (1) familiarization with the data; (2) re-reading transcripts to generate codes; and (3) developing and modifying codes in the context of the entire dataset. As such, the authors produced codes that were closer to the language used by participants and analysis focused on patterns and relationships and further meaning across the extant codes developed deductively and refined inductively within the dataset. The authors included social work and psychology academics with extensive experience in gambling research and researching children and young people. Figure 1 presents the final version of the main themes that after careful discussion, were deemed to best represent a reflective and accurate account of young adults' personal accounts of the initiation of online gambling.

Furthermore, the experiential approach to thematic analysis described by Braun and Clarke (2019, 2023) encouraged researchers to not only explore the ways in which participants contextually situated their experiences, perspectives, and behaviors, but to also reflect on the researchers' own values and role in theme generation. Interpretation was at every turn, especially in the final stages of trying to construct meaning across participant accounts to form a new complex whole (Figure 1) through integration of participants' stories (Mitchell & Clark, 2021). As such, reflexive discussions were regularly held between the three researchers in the analysis, writing, and reporting stages to help resolve any inconsistencies or conflicts with analysis and reporting. These discussions were anchored by the researchers' desire to produce robust and reliable findings that addressed the study's research aim and questions to

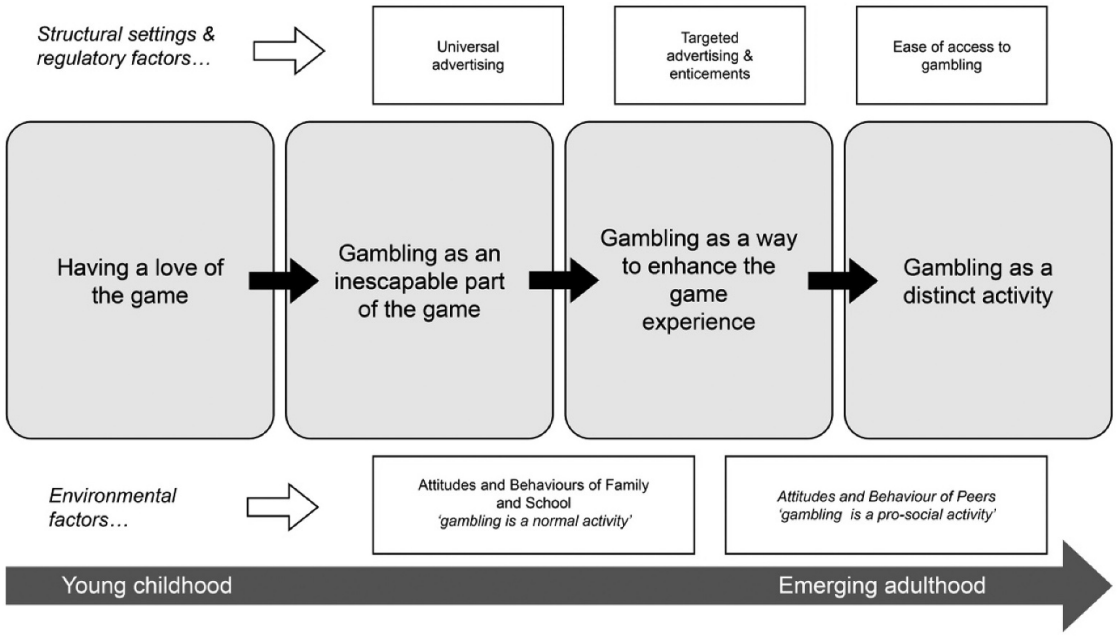


Figure 1. Young people's pathway to online gambling from childhood to emerging adulthood.

pay attention to focus on the intrinsic and external factors that may influence young adults' gambling choices and behaviors. This paper purposefully takes a more systemic lens to focus on what we learnt from young adults about the structural and environmental factors that impact their clear progression from an awareness of and exposure to gambling to active participation in online gambling. As is common to qualitative analysis, it does not attempt to tell 'the whole story' but rather provides a rich description and important contextual understandings of young adults' own perspectives and lived experiences. Additional findings relating to what we also learnt about young adults' more intrinsic motivations to engage with gambling features in video games are available elsewhere (Culbong et al., 2026).

Findings

This section provides a summary of the key themes about gambling uptake derived from young adult's interviews. All young adults initially encountered and engaged in online gambling through two distinct activities either via *video gaming* or an interest in *sports*. Young adults told us it was largely their interest and engagement in these activities that were the catalyst for their awareness and initiation in gambling. Regardless of the entry point being video games or sport, the analysis uncovered that the same patterns and structural and environmental factors were present in young adults' narratives to explain how they progressed from (1) a love of the game; to (2) gambling becoming an inescapable part of the game; to (3) gambling enhancing the game experience; and finally for only some of the participants to (4) gambling becoming a distinct sought-after activity. Figure 1 provides a summary of the pathway to gambling explained by young adults and the factors they said were most influential at each stage. The remaining findings section focuses on providing an account of the four main stages identified in Figure 1 as

described by young people that explains how their engagement with online gambling developed over time.

From the love of video gaming to gambling

A love of the game

Almost half of the participants described having their first gambling experiences through video games which they commonly started playing around 12 years of age. All said they did not set out to gamble within their video game play. Rather they played video games because it was a positive activity that they enjoyed and that sometimes helped them to build and maintain close friendships:

> My best friend, he is overseas and we have had a long-distance friendship for almost four years now. I haven't seen him, but we play every day for minimum of one hour . . . and it kind of strengthens our bond. (ID14, female, 20 years)

Beyond personal friendships, participants described how playing certain games could also provide a valuable sense of connection and belonging to a particular gaming community:

> You know how people say soccer is the universal world game. eSports has that same kind of feel where it's just no matter really what the language you speak, everyone can understand what's happening in the game if they're all fans of the game. And you get that feel at an event no matter where you go. (ID24, male, 24 years)

Gambling as an inescapable part of the game

Young adults readily identified the gambling-like features that were often embedded in the video games they played. The main gambling features described by young adults included loot boxes and gacha. All participants reported engaging in loot boxes or gacha before turning 18 years of age. Many described being commonly lured in through explicit loot box advertising on multiple platforms, including YouTube, Google Play, Facebook, Steam, as well as in-game pop-up advertising:

> The game's [Genshin Impact] YouTube channel, they release character trailers that promote a new release characters or something. That's like an indirectly gambling advertisement, because they're just basically telling you, "Oh, look how appealing this character is. Why don't you spend some money on them?" (ID12, male, 18 years)

Participants described numerous industry strategies that encouraged or 'forced' them to spend money on the gambling features embedded in their games:

> Let's say that if there's a game that you like, but the only way that you can get items is through loot box or gachas or something, and the only way you can get those is by paying actual money. There's no other way to get around it. (ID17, female, 20 years)

Other participants also described specific strategies used by gaming companies such as 'rookie gambling' pools, that draw new players in with a guaranteed rare item. Other games initially offered free 'pulls,' with players eventually having to spend money to progress in the game:

> When you create a gaming account, there's a rookie banner, so it's a gambling pool . . . that's limited only to new players, and you are guaranteed to win . . . it gives new players that dopamine of, oh, I got a top rarity right at the start. (ID18, male, 20 years)

eSports, commonly watched by avid gamers, also included gambling advertising, sometimes for betting on real sports, even for under-age audiences. Participants discussed how eSports betting is now a substantial part of the eSports industry and the gaming community, describing how betting companies sponsor eSports tournaments and show odds on a big screen, akin to NRL or AFL halftime sports betting advertising:

> Sometimes during tournaments, the broadcasting company plays ads about the likely outcomes and how much people are winning from betting these against or for a team during a competition. Then, I wanted to put in a little bit of money so that it feels more exciting to watch a certain match with my favourite team. (ID4, male, 18 years)

Gambling as a way to enhance the game experience

After they had become familiar with, and started to engage with gambling features whilst gaming, participants explained how they began to realize that gambling on loot boxes or gacha could add extra interest, entertainment, or excitement to their chosen game. The excitement described by participants was often strongly associated with gaining sought-after rare items:

> I think that real excitement comes from when you're still expecting that the chances are ridiculously low and then somehow magically you do get the really cool thing. Like "Wow, I got that. That was a really low chance. (ID5, female, 23 years)

Many participants also said they engaged with gambling features as a way to maintain or build connections with friends. For example, gambling on loot boxes was seen as an inherently social activity while gaming with friends or peer groups:

> I could talk to my friends about it because they've done something similar as well, so we can just talk about what we got from pulling things or opening loot crates and stuff. (ID17, female, 20 years)

Enhancing the gaming experience further, participants described online 'opening parties' where they would engage in '*streaming their screens into open the loot boxes.*' When doing this, young adults said they would receive positive reinforcement from their friends:

> "Your friends are like, "Oh, open it. You won't," that sort of thing, sort of egging you on." (ID13, male, 20 years)

Peer pressure appeared to play a key role in driving online gambling behavior, with improved social status being gained if you were able to share and 'show off' the wins and rewards obtained through gambling features:

> I've never opened a case when I'm not showing my friends. I'm in a chat party and I'll be streaming me opening the case. I think most people will stream them, because there's no point to open it by themselves. (ID9, male, 20 years)

Gambling as a distinct focus

Once participants had begun to consistently engage with gambling features in video games, the feelings and thoughts elicited from 'taking a gamble,' began to appeal to them as much or more than the actual game play:

> I loved opening the crates and rolling and getting the chances, hoping for the rarer skin, I just bought a few levels to get a few more of those crates and opened those and got the skin. (ID19, male, 20 years)

The lure of rare game items was so valued by participants that they described the feeling they got from winning these items actually exceeded that of winning money:

> It makes me feel good. I've gambled a couple times at the pokies or something, but I always feel more, I don't know, happy when I win a skin, because I guess it's more tangible to me. (ID9, male, 20 years)

Some in-game items, such as skins, retrieved through loot boxes, were able to replace cash in some gambling markets, making the leap from gaming to gambling more seamless for participants. As such, skins were sometimes described by young adults as an 'investment,' or an 'incentive,' that held 'intrinsic value.' Some participants described how they had started to engage in eSports betting using skins (instead of real money) on unregulated third-party websites that required no age verification:

> In high school, I had friends who would gamble Counter-Strike skins on websites on professional eSports games. And if their team won, they would get back skins equal to the value of the odds. So, if they put in skins and their team won and they were on two X odds, $50 worth of skins and get a hundred dollars worth of skins back. (ID24, male, 24 years)

Participants explained the lack of regulatory oversight made it particularly easy for them to transfer money whilst playing video games, by either using their parents' credit cards or device log-ins, or accessing known illegal sites:

> I could just log on and if I had a Visa or a debit MasterCard, I could just basically go on there and [deposit money for gambling on loot boxes]. And as for other types of gambling, I also was doing it on some third party websites that I don't believe were operating legally. (ID21, male, 21 years)

Spending a significant amount of time online and being exposed to platforms such as simulated gambling, or eSports whilst playing video games as a child was considered by many as the main way they had got into gambling, with some describing how they had then eventually transitioned from gambling on video games to gambling on traditional sports:

> Over time, I started getting an interest in eSports through playing video games ... and gambling mostly on eSports because I was winning more, or I knew more about it and it felt like I was winning more. [And now] I really only do online gambling through channels like Bet365 and Sportsbet. And they have other sports I have interest in, like Formula 1, that I like to gamble on. (ID28, male, 24 years)

From the love of sports to gambling

A love of the game

Young adults articulated that their participation and engagement with sports often acted as an initial entry point to sports betting and other forms of online gambling. For example, sports betting – predominantly on football and basketball – was one of the most common online gambling pursuits of many participants. Those who engaged in this gambling activity, most often described how they had a history of participating in and/or watching sports during childhood: '*Growing up around sporting clubs and stuff, we all got sucked into it* [*gambling*].' Participants explained, however, that prior to developing any interest in sports betting, their interest had purely centered on the sport they were most interested in playing or watching, rather than any gambling components associated with it.

> I'm a very big NBA fan and a very big NRL fan . . . I think if I can throw back to when I was 18, what got me into gambling was the NBA finals. (ID31, male, 22 years)

Gambling as an inescapable part of the game

Participants clearly identified the symbiotic relationship that exists in Australia between sports and gambling, with many saying they had been introduced to gambling through major sporting events. The Melbourne Cup, which is a horse racing carnival in the State of Victoria, earning a public holiday of the same name, was regularly mentioned by the participants as part of their gambling journey:

> At (primary) school Melbourne Cup was played. I have no idea if that would be allowed now. When I won the sweep one year I remember feeling like the coolest kid in school. Things like that throughout my childhood definitely would've contributed to my gambling. (ID32, male, 18 years)

Participating in family or work football tipping competitions, with or without money, was also mentioned as a popular and expected activity that also normalized gambling as an activity that goes hand-in-hand with sports engagement:

> Sweepstakes for those kinds of sporting events [like the World Cup] or footy tipping . . . Typically those kinds of competitions. (ID24, male, 24 years)

Participants explained that gambling became even more prominent in their lives, if they themselves pursued a special interest in playing sport. In many sporting environments, particularly football or basketball, gambling was an unavoidable and regular topic of discussion with peers and coaches. A specific pattern emerged, where young adults would go from talking about their preferred sport with their friends, teammates, and coaches, to betting on these same sports:

> In high school I played basketball every day from 8 to 4 pm with my coach. So we got more time to know each other, we didn't practice during the whole time, but chat. And he would tell me about his betting. He also bet on the NBA games, and I watched NBA, so we got a lot of things to talk about (ID25, male, 24 years)

In addition, participants described how exposure to gambling advertising and promotional materials through following sports could also trigger interest in betting on games. For example, they explained some gambling websites streamed live games online for free

as part of their membership, so gambling platforms became the only way they could watch a 'sports of preference.'

> I watched a lot of NBA . . . and realized the Bet365 stream the game for you, all you need to do is bet a little bit. Then you can watch the games for free. (ID25, male, 24 years)

There was a clear consensus that sports coverage was plagued by gambling advertising and various gambling promotions; with gambling advertising throughout live games of most major sports including AFL and NRL football, cricket, and tennis including *'mid-game or halftime updates on odds'* and various other *'gambling industry promotions.'* Gambling company sponsorships for major sporting events, stadiums, or teams were also mentioned by the participants who were '*disgusted that stadiums are named after betting companies, or Manly* [*Football Club*] *have PointsBet on the front of their jumper.'* Due to the amount of gambling advertising embedded into sports coverage on TV, social media, YouTube, and other streaming platforms, participants stated they were educated about and enticed to gamble from an early age:

> I've always known that betting was a thing since childhood, through advertising. I've been exposed to advertising online as long as I remember, that has made me aware that SportsBet had a website (ID20, male, 20 years)

Gambling as a way to enhance the game experience

When they started to gamble on sports, young adults generally perceived it as being a social activity, and a way to enhance the experience of watching or engaging with sports, particularly when with their friends. As such, young adults explained gambling on sports often took place when they were at a live sports event, or whilst watching the live broadcast of the event with friends. Some participants mentioned within this social context they sometimes felt pressure to participate in gambling:

> We all live together in dorms. When you're living with so many blokes, there's always sports, always rugby on the TV. It sort of starts off as a joke, like, "Oh, place a bet. This will be good fun. We'll have a laugh." (ID32, male, 18 years)

Some participants further explained that discussions with friends or teammates about which bets to place enhanced their experience of watching sport because it provided an avenue for fun competition or to 'show off' their expert knowledge about the game:

> I have a few friends who I talk to about betting, and if they follow other sports and have things they're super confident about and they're like, "Put money on this," I'm like, "Okay, sure. I'll give it a go." . . . They get enjoyment out of being like, "Nice, I got you some money." (ID28, male, 24 years)

For others the main reason they gambled on sports was based on an attempt to make their engagement with sports more exciting or to elevate their experience of supporting their team to the 'next level':

> It's definitely excitement, engagement. Anticipation is the word. It gives you entertainment for however long the game is, two hours . . . And it definitely makes your heart beat a bit faster watching it. (ID32, male, 18 years)

Some participants explained that a higher level of emotional investment was facilitated by placing higher bets, but they also recognized that this could lead to excitement or anger, depending upon the outcome of the game:

> I'm feeling more energetic watching the game, and put more emotion into when, for example, in the first half they lose [by] one goal. At first half you were [feeling] pretty angry, but if they did [win], you are pretty happy. That kind of increases your emotion drive for the game. (ID25, male, 24 years)

Gambling as a distinct or main focus

Participants described that once they had started gambling on sports, the various promotions and inducements actively offered by sports bet companies progressively took the focus away from watching the sport and having fun, to actively seeking ways to further engage with gambling as means to make money:

> The ads during the Australian Open were huge, and actually really changed my behavior on either betting on the next game or going on and checking the odds and seeing how to live bet. (ID34, male, 24 years)

As their sports focus became a gambling focus and their gambling focus became progressively driven by the desire to make easy money, young adults began to make more risky bets:

> You just keep making your multi a lot bigger and the multiplier gets bigger and you see the number get bigger and you're just like, "Oh, this could be big." But the odds get exponentially smaller that you get that. (ID22, male, 23 years)

With a desire to *'make easy money,'* participants explained they could easily become obsessed with working out *'how to beat the system.'* For example, arbitrage betting, the ability to make multiple opposing bets, was seen as a guaranteed way to make money:

> My mate was like "Oh do you want to make some easy money betting?" So he just showed me how to do it. I think it is probably the best one because it has very large bets. (ID8, male, 21 years)

Once focused on gambling, the process of chasing special offers promoted by gambling companies, that allowed you to bet more or to have higher chances of winning, was also commonly described by participants. Some described their friends using such inducements to actively chase their losses. Chasing losses was identified as one of the main indicators of harm in their own gambling or that of their friends:

> I deposited a thousand and I got to about 5,000 and I lost it all. The winning was obviously a big high. And once I lost a little bit, just couldn't stop. It was a pretty bad feeling, but because it was such a big sum I'd go chasing it. I'm always trying to chase losses. (ID30, male, 20 years)

As gambling became the main focus and the bets grew progressively larger, participants explained gambling harms were easier to identify when financial consequences were combined with negative psychological and social impacts:

> My worst loss was about $700 to $800. And I would've been really ashamed and then distressed and, "That was a stupid thing for me to do. Why would I do that?" (ID22, male, 23 years)

> I see the impact, because he'll come into the pub and the first thing he'll want to do is go put a bet on the phone, as opposed to sit down and have a conversation. Then you'll notice a few of the people will be on their phones, placing bets as well, as opposed to engaging in the conversation. (ID34, male, 24 years)

Discussion

This paper reports the findings of an exploratory qualitative study, that examined young adults' initiation of online gambling. The main findings show that while children and young adults had not set out to gamble, engagement with both video games or sports led to increased gambling awareness, interest, and participation over time. A clear and shared narrative emerged whereby participants explained how after initial engagement with gambling, it became an 'inescapable' part of their video game or sports activities. Enticed by peers or prolific advertising by gambling companies, many young adults perceived that gambling could enhance their engagement with their chosen game or sport. Finally for some, gambling became a distinct focal activity, where they could seek enjoyment or financial reward, over and above the enjoyment of the video game or sport they initially loved.

The findings are consistent with current theorization and evidence that suggests young adults' engagement with video gaming and sports can act as a risk factor for gambling participation (Constandt et al., 2022; Delfabbro & King, 2020; Dussault et al., 2017; McGee, 2020; Molde et al., 2019; Montiel et al., 2022; Spicer et al., 2022). The findings lend some support to the gateway theory that claims engaging with gambling-like features in video games provides a convenient entry point to the use of online gambling products (González-Cabrera et al., 2023; Molde et al., 2019; Spicer et al., 2022). Their initial engagement with loot boxes as children led participants to later engaging in skin betting and trading on eSports betting through unregulated third-party sites, providing an illustrative example of this gambling 'gateway.' The identification of the common structural or environmental factors that impacted young adults' gambling choices and behaviors (seen in Figure 1) was also one of the main contributions of this study and an important consideration in public health approaches to gambling.

Our findings extend earlier qualitative research by Deans et al. (2016), highlighting structural and environmental factors as major drivers of online gambling behaviors in young men. Participants identified structural factors, including limited regulation and frequent universal and targeted advertising, as key contributors. This supports other studies that have found children and young adults have ease of access to a range of gambling activities through a wide range of products and platforms (Deans et al., 2017; McGee, 2020; Nyemcsok et al., 2021). Participants who engaged with video gaming tended to report starting gambling at a younger age. These accounts suggest that protections for children from gambling-like features within video games warrant further policy and research attention. Some countries such as Belgium have started to address this by banning loot boxes with various amounts of success (Xiao et al., 2022) but countries like the UK and Australia are yet to adopt these practices.

Additionally, community values and norms that result in young adults perceiving gambling as a normal, fun, and pro-social activity also contributed to young adults' uptake and participation in gambling. In line with previous studies (Hing, Smith, et al.,

2022; Suomi et al., 2022) young adults in this study recalled consistent exposure to gambling throughout their childhood, either through parents, school, or friends. Again, this finding lends support to previous studies that have found a link between parental and community exposure and experiences and likelihood of gambling in young people (McCarthy et al., 2020; J. Smith et al., 2025; Suomi et al., 2022).

One of the most striking findings of this study was the convergence of young adults' accounts across two recreational domains that are typically examined separately in the literature. Although sports and gaming were analyzed inductively and independently, participants in both groups described gambling and gambling-like content becoming embedded within the sports and gaming environments they engaged with during childhood and adolescence. This reflects broader concerns about the growing presence of gambling-related content in two otherwise distinct recreational domains: sport and digital gaming (DiCenso et al., 2024; Grosemans et al., 2024). In sport, gambling has become increasingly normalized through advertising, sponsorship, club environments, and the cultivation of betting-related expertise among fans (McGee, 2020). In digital gaming, gambling-like practices are evident in the monetization of some games through loot boxes, gacha mechanics, skin betting, and other chance-based purchasing systems (Brevers et al., 2022; Thulin et al., 2025).

Beyond the presence of gambling content in both domains, participants described a similar trajectory from recreational engagement to gambling. In both groups, young adults began with a genuine enthusiasm for the game or sport and did not set out to gamble. Gambling then became an unavoidable feature of that environment, whether through wagering advertising and sponsorship in sport or loot boxes and skin trading in gaming. It was subsequently taken up as a way of deepening engagement with the original activity, adding stakes, social connection with peers, or a means of demonstrating knowledge and expertise. For some, gambling eventually became decoupled from the original activity and pursued in its own right. That this common sequence emerged from separate inductive analyses suggests the pathway may be driven less by the particular characteristics of sport or gaming than by shared mechanisms: the commercial embedding of gambling within valued leisure activities, its normalization within peer cultures, and the framing of gambling as an extension of existing skill, knowledge and fandom. This has two implications. Theoretically, it suggests that sport- and gaming-related gambling may be better understood as variations of a broader process through which gambling is integrated into young people's leisure, rather than as distinct phenomena. Practically, it suggests that prevention and regulatory responses may be more effective if they address these shared mechanisms across recreational settings, rather than responding to each domain in isolation.

However, the gaming-gambling relationship requires important qualification. Unlike the highly visible relationship between wagering and many major sporting codes, gambling-like monetization is not a feature of all video games. Rather, it is concentrated in particular commercial sectors, including mobile, free-to-play, live-service, and blockbuster games, many of which have mass-market appeal and substantial youth audiences. Independent developers and smaller studios have often rejected these monetization practices on ethical grounds. Drawing on Brock and Johnson's (2021) formulation of the 'gamblification of digital games,' our findings are therefore best understood as relating to specific commercialized segments of gaming, where game design,

monetization, and platform economies may normalize chance-based rewards, repeated spending, and gambling-like forms of engagement.

Although these findings identify participation in video gaming and sports as a possible pathway to gambling engagement, these activities also have many positive aspects for children and young adults, including enhancing prosocial behaviors, health, and cognitive performance (Chaarani et al., 2022; Li & Shao, 2022). Participants' accounts centered predominantly on structural and social influences, such as advertising, ease of access, and the normalization of gambling among family and peers, rather than on individual factors. These accounts are consistent with arguments for public health approaches that address the environments in which young people encounter gambling (Blank et al., 2021; Price et al., 2021; Van Schalkwyk et al., 2021). In particular, participants' descriptions of accessing gambling and gambling-like products before the age of 18, including through unregulated third-party skin betting sites, suggest that the effectiveness of existing age restrictions warrants further investigation (Ukhova et al., 2024).

Limitations and future directions

While a strength of the current study lies in the rich information provided by young adults themselves, our findings should be interpreted with some caution. Due to our study relying on a relatively small sample of participants who self-identified as engaging in online gambling in the last 12 months, our findings cannot be applied to the broader population of young adults to support the hypothesis that engagement with video gaming and sports causes or increases the likelihood of gambling or for that matter gambling harm. Rather, our findings offer important insights to the extant knowledge on this emerging topic, by specifying – from young adults' perspectives – why and how an otherwise normal and healthy engagement with video gaming and sports can lead to an interest and participation in gambling. The findings of this exploratory qualitative study, overall, provide a consistent narrative of how children may progress from engagement with video games or sports to participation in gambling and what structural and environmental factors may promote this trajectory.

Another limitation of this study is that we did not examine factors related to problem gambling. Other qualitative research, for example, found that those experiencing problem gambling relating to loot box purchases, are more likely to be motivated by feelings of compulsion, being influenced by streamers and professional gamers, and were also afraid of missing out on promotional offers, compared to young people engaging with loot boxes without gambling problems (Nicklin et al., 2021). Further, we were not able to identify individual characteristics or protective or risk factors that contributed to why only some of the participants transitioned to gambling becoming a distinct and sought-after activity and why only a smaller number stated they experienced gambling harm. Instead, young adults' own accounts tended to highlight the structural and environmental factors that impacted on them being aware of gambling and susceptible to gambling participation.

Further research that can identify which children and young adults may be more susceptible to gambling participation and why would be particularly helpful. Current research indicates individual risk factors are likely to include engaging in vaping, smoking, alcohol, and illicit drug use (Noble et al., 2025), but little is known about how children or young adults perceive or experience these co-existing risky activities, or the

protective factors they believe may help mitigate risk or harm. As this study illustrates, asking young adults themselves for their own perspectives and experiences will be critical to strengthening the evidence base in this burgeoning area of study (OECD, 2025).

Conclusion

Online gambling among young adults, particularly young men, has been identified as an area of growing public concern. This paper extends understanding of how engagement with sports and video gaming during childhood and adolescence may act as a pathway to gambling uptake. In participants' accounts, structural and environmental factors played a prominent role in their progression from enthusiasm for a game or sport, to perceiving gambling as an unavoidable part of that activity, and then to viewing it as a way to enhance their engagement. These factors included widespread gambling advertising, ease of access to gambling, and the normalization of gambling within families and communities. This trajectory was consistent across sports and gaming, suggesting shared mechanisms through which gambling becomes embedded in young people's leisure activities. For some participants, gambling later became an activity pursued in its own right. Further research is needed to examine how these factors operate across recreational settings and to identify which young people are most likely to progress along this pathway.

Author contributions

CRediT: **Aino Suomi:** Conceptualization, Data curation, Funding acquisition, Investigation, Methodology, Resources, Supervision, Writing – original draft; **Debbie Noble-Carr:** Formal analysis, Investigation, Methodology, Project administration, Writing – original draft; **Hunter Culbong:** Conceptualization, Data curation, Investigation, Project administration, Writing – review & editing; **Thomas Stevens:** Investigation, Writing – review & editing.

Disclosure statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the author(s).

Funding

This project was funded by the ACT Gambling and Racing Commission, Canberra, Australian Capital Territory, Australia. The opinions, comments and/or analysis expressed in this report do not necessarily represent the views of the ACT Gambling and Racing Commission or the ACT Government.

Notes on contributors

Aino Suomi (MPsych, PhD), Director of the Centre for Gambling Research, will lead the project. She is a trained child and family psychologist and a public health researcher with nearly 20 years of experience in research of family impacts of gambling harm. She is internationally renowned of her work about the intersection of child and family wellbeing and gambling harm, impacts of parental gambling on children, including family and intimate partner violence and using population health

methodologies to examine gambling harm. As examples of experience achieving relevant outcomes, Aino leads programmatic research on young people and gambling harm, including a mix of quantitative research, co-design activities and qualitative interviews of young people exposed to gambling harm.

Dr Debbie Noble-Carr is a Social Worker and Senior Research Officer at the Centre for Gambling Research, ANU. Since qualifying as social worker in 1996, Debbie has worked in a range of health and welfare settings providing support to vulnerable children, young people and their families. She is a leading qualitative researcher with vulnerable children and young people; managing research projects at the Australian Institute of Health and Welfare, the Institute of Child Protection Studies at Australian Catholic University and the Australian National University.

Hunter Culbong is a PhD student and Academic Associate at ANU@POLIS. His current position at ANU has involved contribution to projects across several disciplines, including mental health service access for Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander youth, and criminal justice experiences in Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander communities.

Thomas Stevens is the Director of Sector Development, Workforce Capability & Communications at the Youth Coalition of the ACT. Thomas dedicated himself to making significant contributions in policy development, research and evaluation, sector development, and advocacy efforts focused on issues concerning young people in the ACT. With more than 12 years of experience, he possesses extensive expertise in design, communications and marketing and also holds a graduate diploma in Digital Marketing.

Data availability statement

The data used for this study is confidential.

References

Albarrán-Torres, C. (2018). *Digital gambling: Theorizing gamble-play media*. Routledge.

Australian Communications and Media Authority. (2022). *Online gambling in Australia: Findings from the 2021 ACMA annual consumer survey*. https://www.acma.gov.au/sites/default/files/2022-02/Online%20gambling%20in%20Australia.pdf

Blank, L., Baxter, S., Woods, H. B., & Goyder, E. (2021). Interventions to reduce the public health burden of gambling-related harms: A mapping review. *Lancet Public Health*, *6*(1), e50–e63. https://doi.org/10.1016/S2468-2667(20)30230-9

Bolzan, N., & Gale, F. (2011). Expect the unexpected. *Child Indicators Research*, *4*(2), 269–281. https://doi.org/10.1007/s12187-010-9098-7

Bragg, S. (2010). *Consulting young people: A literature review*. CCE.

Braun, V., & Clarke, V. (2006). Using thematic analysis in psychology. *Qualitative Research in Psychology*, *3*(2), 77–101. https://doi.org/10.1191/1478088706qp063oa

Braun, V., & Clarke, V. (2019). Reflecting on reflexive thematic analysis. *Qualitative Research in Sport, Exercise & Health*, *11*(4), 589–597. https://doi.org/10.1080/2159676X.2019.1628806

Braun, V., & Clarke, V. (2023). Toward good practice in thematic analysis: Avoiding common problems and be(com)ing a knowing researcher. *International Journal of Transgender Health*, *24*(1), 1, 1–6. https://doi.org/10.1080/26895269.2022.2129597

Brevers, D., Vögele, C., & Billieux, J. (2022). *The evolving landscape of sports betting: A risk for young people*? In *Wohlbefinden und gesundheit im jugendalter: Theoretische perspektiven, empirische befunde und Praxisansätze* (pp. 363–392). Springer Fachmedien Wiesbaden.

Brock, T., & Johnson, M. (2021). The gamblification of digital games. *Journal of Consumer Culture*, *21*(1), 3–13. https://doi.org/10.1177/1469540521993904

Chaarani, B., Ortigara, J., Yuan, D., Loso, H., Potter, A., & Garavan, H. P. (2022). Association of video gaming with cognitive performance among children. *JAMA network open*, *5*(10), e2235721. https://doi.org/10.1001/jamanetworkopen.2022.35721

Constandt, B., Rosiers, J., Moernaut, J., Van Der Hoeven, S., & Willem, A. (2022). Part of the game? Exploring the prevalence and normalization of gambling in Belgian sports clubs. *International Journal of Environmental Research and Public Health*, *19*(11), 6527. https://doi.org/10.3390/ijerph19116527

Culbong, H., Masters, A., Noble-Carr, D., & Suomi, A. (2026). Why do young people engage with gambling features in videogames: Rewards and motivations. *Journal of Youth Studies*, 1–18.

Deans, E. G., Thomas, S. L., Daube, M., & Derevensky, J. (2016). "I can sit on the beach and punt through my mobile phone": The influence of physical and online environments on the gambling risk behaviours of young men. *Social Science and Medicine*, *166*, 110–119.

Deans, E. G., Thomas, S. L., Daube, M., & Derevensky, J. (2017). The role of peer influences on the normalisation of sports wagering: A qualitative study of Australian men. *Addiction Research & Theory*, *25*(2), 103–113. https://doi.org/10.1080/16066359.2016.1205042

Delfabbro, P., & King, D. L. (2020). Gaming-gambling convergence: Evaluating evidence for the 'gateway'hypothesis. *International Gambling Studies*, *20*(3), 380–392. https://doi.org/10.1080/14459795.2020.1768430

Delfabbro, P., King, D., Williams, J., & Georgiou, N. (2021). Cryptocurrency trading, gambling and problem gambling. *Addictive Behaviors*, *122*, 107021. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.addbeh.2021.107021

DiCenso, G., Delfabbro, P., & King, D. L. (2024). Examining the role of sports betting marketing in youth problem gambling. *Journal of Gambling Studies*, *40*(4), 2005–2025. https://doi.org/10.1007/s10899-024-10347-x

Drummond, A., Sauer, J. D., Ferguson, C. J., & Hall, L. C. (2020). The relationship between problem gambling, excessive gaming, psychological distress and spending on loot boxes in Aotearoa New Zealand, Australia, and the United States-A cross-national survey. *PLOS ONE*, *15*(3), e0230378. https://doi.org/10.1371/journal.pone.0230378

Dussault, F., Brunelle, N., Kairouz, S., Rousseau, M., Leclerc, D., Tremblay, J., Cousineau, M., & Dufour, M. (2017). Transition from playing with simulated gambling games to gambling with real money: A longitudinal study in adolescence. *International Gambling Studies*, *17*(3), 386–400. https://doi.org/10.1080/14459795.2017.1343366

Fereday, J., & Muir-Cochrane, E. (2006). Demonstrating rigor using thematic analysis: A hybrid approach of inductive and deductive coding and theme development. *International Journal of Qualitative Methods*, *5*(1), 80–92. https://doi.org/10.1177/160940690600500107

Flayelle, M., Brevers, D., King, D. L., Maurage, P., Perales, J. C., & Billieux, J. (2023). A taxonomy of technology design features that promote potentially addictive online behaviours. *Nature Reviews Psychology*, *2*(3), 136–150. https://doi.org/10.1038/s44159-023-00153-4

Gainsbury, S. M. (2015). Online gambling addiction: The relationship between internet gambling and disordered gambling. *Current Addiction Reports*, *2*(2), 185–193. https://doi.org/10.1007/s40429-015-0057-8

Gomez, R. J., & Ryan, T. N. (2016). Speaking out: Youth Led research as a methodology used with homeless youth. *Child and Adolescent Social Work Journal*, *33*(2), 185–193. https://doi.org/10.1007/s10560-015-0414-4

González-Cabrera, J., Basterra-González, A., Ortega-Barón, J., Caba-Machado, V., Díaz-López, A., Pontes, H. M., & Machimbarrena, J. M. (2023). Loot box purchases and their relationship with internet gaming disorder and online gambling disorder in adolescents: A prospective study. *Computers in Human Behavior*, *143*, 107685. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.chb.2023.107685

Greer, N., Boyle, C. M., & Jenkinson, R. (2022). *Harms associated with loot boxes, simulated gambling and other in-game purchases in video games: a review of the evidence*. Australian Gambling Research Centre & Australian Institute of Family Studies.

Greer, N., Rockloff, M., Hing, N., Browne, M., & King, D. L. (2023). Skin gambling contributes to gambling problems and harm after controlling for other forms of traditional gambling. *Journal of Gambling Studies*, *39*(1), 225–247. https://doi.org/10.1007/s10899-022-10111-z

Grosemans, E., De Cock, R., Bradt, L., & Zaman, B. (2024). More than loot boxes: The role of video game streams and gambling-like elements in the gaming-gambling connection among adolescents. *Journal of Gambling Issues*. https://doi.org/10.4309/GBVY4097

Hill, M. (2006). Children's voices on ways of having a voice: Children's and young people's perspectives on methods used in research and consultation. *Childhood*, *13*(1), 69–89. https://doi.org/10.1177/0907568206059972

Hing, N., Russell, A., Browne, M., Rockloff, M., Greer, N., Rawat, V., & Woo, L. (2021). *The second national study of interactive gambling in Australia (2019–20)*.

Hing, N., Russell, A. M., Black, A., Rockloff, M., Browne, M., Rawat, V., Greer, N., Stevens, M., Dowling, N. A., Merkouris, S., King, D. L., Salonen, A. H., Breen, H., & Woo, L. (2022). Gambling prevalence and gambling problems amongst land-based-only, online-only and mixed-mode gamblers in Australia: A national study. *Computers in Human Behavior*, *132*, 107269. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.chb.2022.107269

Hing, N., Smith, M., Rockloff, M., Thorne, H., Russell, A. M., Dowling, N. A., & Breen, H. (2022). How structural changes in online gambling are shaping the contemporary experiences and behaviours of online gamblers: An interview study. *BMC Public Health*, *22*(1), 1620. https://doi.org/10.1186/s12889-022-14019-6

Husbands, S., Mitchell, P. M., & Coast, J. (2020). A systematic review of the use and quality of qualitative methods in concept elicitation for measures with children and young people. *The Patient*, *13*(3), 257. https://doi.org/10.1007/s40271-020-00414-x

Jenkinson, R., de Lacey-Vawdon, C., & Carroll, M. (2018). *Weighing up the odds: Young men, sports and betting*. Victorian Responsible Gambling Foundation.

Jenny, S. E., Manning, R. D., Keiper, M. C., & Olrich, T. W. (2017). Virtual (ly) athletes: Where eSports fit within the definition of "Sport". *Quest*, *69*(1), 1–18. https://doi.org/10.1080/00336297.2016.1144517

Johnson, V. (2017). Moving beyond voice in children and young people's participation. *Action Research*, *15*(1), 104–124. https://doi.org/10.1177/1476750317698025

Kim, H. S., & King, D. L. (2020). Gambling-gaming convergence: New developments and future directions. *International Gambling Studies*, *20*(3), 373–379.

King, D. L., Gainsbury, S. M., Delfabbro, P. H., Hing, N., & Abarbanel, B. (2015). Distinguishing between gaming and gambling activities in addiction research. *Journal of Behavioral Addictions*, *4*(4), 215–220.

Lester, S. (1999). *An introduction to phenomenological research*. Stan Lester Developments.

Li, J., & Shao, W. (2022). Influence of sports activities on prosocial behavior of children and adolescents: A systematic literature review. *International Journal of Environmental Research and Public Health*, *19*(11), 6484. https://doi.org/10.3390/ijerph19116484

McCarthy, S., Thomas, S., Pitt, H., Daube, M., & Cassidy, R. (2020). 'It's a tradition to go down to the pokies on your 18th birthday'-the normalisation of gambling for young women in Australia. *Australian and New Zealand Journal of Public Health*, *44*(5), 376–381. https://doi.org/10.1111/1753-6405.13024

McGee, D. (2020). On the normalisation of online sports gambling among young adult men in the UK: A public health perspective. *Public Health*, *184*, 89–94. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.puhe.2020.04.018

Mitchell, K. M., & Clark, A. M. (2021). Enhance your qualitative analysis with writing: Four principles of writing as inquiry. *International Journal of Qualitative Methods*, *20*, 1–5. https://doi.org/10.1177/16094069211057997

Molde, H., Holmøy, B., Merkesdal, A. G., Torsheim, T., Mentzoni, R. A., Hanns, D., Sagoe, D., & Pallesen, S. (2019). Are video games a gateway to gambling? A longitudinal study based on a representative Norwegian sample. *Journal of Gambling Studies*, *35*(2), 545–557. https://doi.org/10.1007/s10899-018-9781-z

Montiel, I., Basterra-González, A., Machimbarrena, J. M., Ortega-Barón, J., & González-Cabrera, J. (2022). Loot box engagement: A scoping review of primary studies on prevalence and association with problematic gaming and gambling. *PLOS ONE*, *17*(1), e0263177. https://doi.org/10.1371/journal.pone.0263177

Nicklin, L. L., Spicer, S. G., Close, J., Parke, J., Smith, O., Raymen, T., Lloyd, J., & Lloyd, J. (2021). "It's the attraction of winning that draws you in"-A qualitative investigation of reasons and facilitators for videogame loot box engagement in UK gamers. *Journal of Clinical Medicine*, *10* (10), 2103. https://doi.org/10.3390/jcm10102103

Noble, N., Freund, M., Scully, M., Clapham, M., & Leigh, L. (2025). *The prevalence and correlates of gambling in secondary school students in Victoria and New South Wales, Australia, 2022–23*. State Government of Victoria.

Nyemcsok, C., Thomas, S. L., Pitt, H., Pettigrew, S., Cassidy, R., & Daube, M. (2021). Young people's reflections on the factors contributing to the normalisation of gambling in Australia. *Australian and New Zealand Journal of Public Health*, *45*(2), 165–170. https://doi.org/10.1111/1753-6405.13063

OECD. (2025). *How's life for children in the digital age?* OECD Publishing. https://doi.org/10.1787/0854b900-en

Padgett, D. (2008). *Qualitative methods in social work research* (2nd ed.). Sage Publications.

Price, A., Hilbrecht, M., & Billi, R. (2021). Charting a path towards a public health approach for gambling harm prevention. *Journal of Public Health*, *29*(1), 37–53. https://doi.org/10.1007/s10389-020-01437-2

Purdy, N., & Spears, B. (2020). Co-participatory approaches to research with children and young people. *Pastoral Care in Education*, *38*(3), 187–190. https://doi.org/10.1080/02643944.2020.1788816

Roberts, K., Dowell, A., & Nie, J. B. (2019). Attempting rigour and replicability in thematic analysis of qualitative research data: A case study codebook development. *BMC Medical Research Methodology*, *19*(1), 1–8. https://doi.org/10.1186/s12874-019-0707-y

Rockloff, M., Russell, A. M. T., Browne, M., & Hing, N. (2025). *2024 ACT gambling survey*. Experimental Gambling Research Laboratory, CQUniversity Australia.

Saldana, J. (2016). *The coding manual for qualitative researchers*. Sage Publications Inc.

Seal, E., Cardak, B. A., Nicholson, M., Donaldson, A., O'halloran, P., Randle, E., & Staley, K. (2022). The gambling behaviour and attitudes to sports betting of sports fans. *Journal of Gambling Studies*, *38*(4), 1371–1403. https://doi.org/10.1007/s10899-021-10101-7

Siste, K., King, D. L., Hanafi, E., Sen, L. T., Adrian, A., & Murtani, B. J. (2025). Scrutinizing the gateway relationship between gaming and gambling disorder: Scoping review with a focus on the Southeast Asian region. *JMIR Serious Games*, *13*(1), e59740.

Smith, J. A., Flowers, P., & Larkin, M. (2009). *Interpretative phenomenological analysis: Theory, method and research*. Sage.

Smith, J., Wright, S., Dighton, G., Dymond, S., & Torrance, J. (2025). The influence of family on gambling behaviours: A rapid review of emergent literature. *International Journal of Mental Health and Addiction*, *24*(3), 1–21. https://doi.org/10.1007/s11469-025-01505-2

Spicer, S. G., Nicklin, L. L., Uther, M., Lloyd, J., Lloyd, H., & Close, J. (2022). Loot boxes, problem gambling and problem video gaming: A systematic review and meta-synthesis. *New Media and Society*, *24*(4), 1001–1022. https://doi.org/10.1177/14614448211027175

Suomi, A., Bailey, M., Lucas, N., Dowling, N., & Delfabbro, P. (2022). "It's like you're not even there . . . ": Gambling harm experienced by children of gambling parents. *Children & Youth Services Review*, *145*, 1–9. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.childyouth.2022.106800

Suomi, A., Hahn, M., & Biddle, N. (2024). *Gambling participation in Australia, 2024: Trends over time and profiles associated with online gambling*. ANU@POLIS working paper. https://polis.cass.anu.edu.au/files/docs/2025/6/Gambling_in_Australia_2024_002.pdf

Suomi, A., Kim, J., Biddle, N., Dowling, N. A., Hahn, M., Cowlishaw, S., Butterworth, P., Thomas, A., Hodgins, D., Heywood, W., Scott, P., & Myers, P. (2024). *Victorian population gambling and health study 2023*, State Government of Victoria. https://files.justice.vic.gov.au/2024-09/Victorian_population_gambling_and_health_study_2023-Final_report.pdf

Thomas, C., Cockcroft, E., Jenkins, G., & Liabo, K. (2025). Working with children and young people in research: Supportive practices and pathways to impact. *Journal of Child Health Care*, *29*(1), 34–52. https://doi.org/10.1177/13674935231171451

Thulin, M. C., Snaychuk, L. A., Vieira, J. L., Coelho, S. G., & Kim, H. S. (2025). The gamblification of video games: A case study on loot boxes. In *Digital addictions* (pp. 139–151). Springer.

Ukhova, D., Marionneau, V., Nikkinen, J., & Wardle, H. (2024). Public health approaches to gambling: A global review of legislative trends. *Lancet Public Health*, *9*(1), e57–e67. https://doi.org/10.1016/S2468-2667(23)00221-9

Van Schalkwyk, M. C., Petticrew, M., Cassidy, R., Adams, P., McKee, M., Reynolds, J., & Orford, J. (2021). A public health approach to gambling regulation: Countering powerful influences. *Lancet Public Health*, *6*(8), e614–e619. https://doi.org/10.1016/S2468-2667(21)00098-0

Waller, T., & Bitou, A. (2011). Research with children: Three challenges for participatory research in early childhood. *European Early Childhood Education Research Journal*, *19*(1), 5–20. https://doi.org/10.1080/1350293X.2011.548964

Xiao, L. Y., Henderson, L. L., Nielsen, R. K., & Newall, P. W. (2022). Regulating gambling-like video game loot boxes: A public health framework comparing industry self-regulation, existing national legal approaches, and other potential approaches. *Current Addiction Reports*, *9*(3), 163–178. https://doi.org/10.1007/s40429-022-00424-9